Here is what appeared then in the press, which indicates the situation in the courtroom.

KIRAN BEDI REFUSES TO TAKE OATH

Mrs Kiran Bedi refused to take oath before Justices Wadhwa and Goswami on Thursday [19 May 1988]. She was asked to show cause by Friday why she should not be prosecuted for contempt of court.

Subinspector Jinder Singh, who was to have been cross-examined before the panel on Thursday along with Mrs Bedi, did not turn up in the court. He was issued non-bailable warrants to appear before the court on 23 May.

Mrs Bedi's counsel told the two-judge panel that he would move higher courts against their ruling. The Tis Hazari Bar Association, meanwhile, filed petitions before the High Court and the Supreme Court to prevent any exparte stay of the proceedings.

Mrs Bedi's refusal to take oath came after her counsel had argued that, virtually being an accused before the committee, she was not bound to take oath. The judges, however, ordered that she be cross-examined. 'I beg leave to state that I do not wish to make any statement,' Mrs Bedi said. The courtroom erupted with cries of 'contempt'. The show-cause notice was later served on Mrs Bedi as the court adjourned.

Simultaneously, the court ordered that Mr Ved Marwah, former police chief, and Mr M. S. Sandhu, ex-additional DCP, be present on Friday for cross-examination.

Dozens of lawyers had crammed the courtroom on Thursday to witness Mrs Bedi's testimony. Five minutes after the judges had taken their seats, there was a buzz of excitement. Mr G. Ramaswami, additional solicitor-general, walked in to defend the police department. His appearance on Monday had generated a spate of objections from the bar associations.

Mr Ramaswami first made his own position in the matter clear. He said he was duty-bound to accept the brief since the Government had ordered him to do so. 'The lawyers did not discuss any of their confidential case strategy with me. My conscience is clear,' Mr Ramaswami said.

Mr Ramaswami then addressed himself to the case. He said the present inquiry was not just for fact-finding but for probing specific charges against specific individuals. 'Mrs Bedi is almost the accused before this committee,' he said.

Mr Ramaswami said that if a person refused to testify before the committee when he was called as an ordinary witness, he could be penalised. But, he said, a virtual accused could not be compelled to depose.

Mr Ramaswami cited the case of Mrs Indira Gandhi who had refused to depose before the [J.C.] Shah Commission under similar circumstances. 'The high court upheld her right to stay away from the witness box,' he said.

'Are you saying Mrs Bedi will not take oath?' asked Justice Wadhwa. Mr Ramaswami said she would appear later, after he had had a chance to cross-examine those who had deposed against her.

The judges ruled there was a fundamental difference between Mrs Gandhi's case and Mrs Bedi's case. Mrs Gandhi had not filed an affidavit before the commission while Mrs Bedi had done so: 'She is only being cross-examined on her own affidavit,' said Justice Goswami.

The judges asked SI Jinder Singh to take the box. The subinspector was not present. Non-bailable warrants were issued for him to appear on 23 May.

Mrs Bedi was then called to the box. 'Mrs Bedi, have you filed an affidavit?' asked Justice